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Somebody, Anybody, Applaud Me!

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Somebody, Anybody, Applaud Me!

Let another praise you, and not your own mouth; someone else, and not your own lips. (Proverbs 27:2)

It is not good to eat too much honey, nor is it honorable to seek one's own honor. (Proverbs 25:27)

My godly father had an expression which pretty much “nailed it” in describing people who are filled with themselves. He said with his wry smile, “I’d like to buy ’em for what they’re worth and sell ’em for what they think they’re worth.” Big profit margin there!

If there ever were industries that specialize in inflated egos, exaggerated bios, out-of-reality press releases, and over-the-top self-adulation, they are entertainment and politics. Many in both camps pay an entire staff of people to tell others how wonderful they are, since their own all-out efforts at self-praise are totally insufficient!

Principle: If we are really great, people will find it out without our telling them. Telling them how great we are usually creates the opposite impression in their minds.

The Scriptures have a different emphasis from self-promotion. They support the pursuit of stature, not status. The principle articulated by Jesus is that “Everyone who exalts himself will be humbled, and he who humbles himself will be exalted” (Luke 18:14). This concept is a tough sell in this culture!

I know of a Christian leader who desperately wanted to be called “Doctor.” He was so desperate that he wrote to the presidents of a number of Christian colleges soliciting an honorary doctorate. Incredibly, one school gave him a DD-Donated Dignity. I always wondered why it didn’t seem hollow to him when he insisted that he be called “Doctor.” He had connived to get the title rather than working for years in an established university to get the honor like most others bearing the title.

Principle: Earthly honor soon dies, but humbling oneself before God brings the acclaim of heaven and its angels forever.

King Solomon and his friends were unimpressed with those who were impressed with themselves. They directed, in the two passages cited above, that people let praise come from the mouths of others, not their own.

Finally, I think the reason that prideful self-exaltation is condemned in Scriptures is there is no such thing as a “self-made person.” If there were, you could spot that person in a second by the defects in workmanship! Allowing others to recognize the character of God in us—and applaud it—is far more rewarding than trumpeting our own achievements and, thus, blaspheming their True Giver.

Principle: Self-praise steals from God the honor due Him, for no one ever achieves anything worthwhile apart from the gifts, abilities, and grace of his Maker.

Finally, the writers of Proverbs have a fascinating figure of speech to illustrate the counterproductive nature of self-promotion—honey gorging. Honey is sweet to the lips and rich addition to food when taken in small quantities, but I don’t know anyone who could stand sitting down to a gallon container of honey and trying to eat all of it. Very quickly it becomes too much of a good thing and turns bitter to the taste. I know a person who can barely speak a single sentence without including some self-aggrandizing reference. A little of that goes a long way.

The Book declares that if we “humble ourselves in the sight of the Lord, HE will lift us up!”

[from “*Wisdom for the Trenches*” by Dr. Larry W. Poland]